

## 4 READING & SPEAKING

- a Look at this photo of Songdo, a new city in South Korea. What do you think might be the advantages or disadvantages of living there?



- b Now read an article about Songdo. Answer the questions with a partner.

- 1 What are the three main advantages of living in Songdo?
- 2 Which two things that were promised haven't happened yet?
- 3 What other disadvantages are mentioned?

- c Read the article again. For each of the **highlighted** words and phrases, choose the best meaning, a or b.

- 1 **a** advantages    **b** disadvantages
- 2 **a** break its promise    **b** keep its promise
- 3 **a** leaving home    **b** going home
- 4 **a** not enough    **b** too much
- 5 **a** very advanced    **b** very simple
- 6 **a** be different from    **b** be similar to
- 7 **a** overpopulated    **b** underpopulated
- 8 **a** close together    **b** spread out

- d Talk to a partner.

- 1 If you went to live in Songdo, what would you like best and what would you miss the most?
- 2 What's the most modern city you've ever been to? Why did you go there? What did you think of it?
- 3 If you had to choose between an ultra-modern megacity and a classically beautiful old city, which would you prefer?
- 4 What is the approximate population of your city or nearest big city? Do you think it will grow? What effect might the change in population have on the city and its services?

## Is this the future

Three years ago, 35-year-old English teacher Lee Mi-Jung moved with her husband from the small coastal city of Pohang across the South Korean peninsula to Songdo. Described as the world's 'smartest city', it was planned as a showpiece of 21st-century urban design, promising an efficient rubbish system, an abundance of parks, and a vibrant international community – all the 'perks of megacity Seoul without the capital city's crowded pavements, choking traffic, and air pollution. The city claimed to do 'nothing less than banish the problems created by modern urban life.' And for foreign corporations looking for access to Asian economies, Songdo would be a glitzy business capital to rival Hong Kong and Shanghai. 'I'd imagined this would be a well-designed city, that it would be new, modernized, and simple – unlike other cities,' says Lee. 'So my expectations were high.'

As far as hi-tech conveniences go, Songdo does <sup>2</sup>deliver. Pneumatic tubes send rubbish straight from Lee's home to an underground waste facility, where it's sorted, recycled, or burned for energy generation. Everything, from the lights, to the temperature in her apartment, can be adjusted via a central control panel, or from her phone. During the winter, she can warm up the apartment before <sup>3</sup>heading home. But the one thing she hasn't been able to find is a vibrant community.

'When I first came here during the winter,' Lee says, 'I felt something cold.' She wasn't just talking about the coldness of the weather, or the chilly modernism of the concrete high rises all over town. She felt <sup>4</sup>a lack of human warmth from neighbourhood interaction. 'There's an online forum where we share our complaints,' she said, 'But only on the internet – not face to face.'

Songdo was built on reclaimed land from the Yellow Sea. The 1,500-acre development sits an hour outside of Seoul. It was planned as an eco-city. Its buildings and streets have sensors that monitor energy use and traffic flow. There's a <sup>5</sup>state-of-the-art water-recycling facility and plenty of green spaces, including a 100-acre seaside park modelled on, and named after, New York City's Central Park.

## 4 a Advantages

- high technologies
- testing of new studies

## Disadvantages

- less green places: parks, etc.
- not human size of buildings.

b) 1) Main advantage that everything is automatic, ecological and thought of. Every part of life is taken care of by high technology.

2) There isn't vibrant community and a lack of services nearby.

3) The other main problem is that city has one third number of people it was designed for.

d) 1) I do like the eco theme of the city, I'd be pleased to live in an atmosphere of "green" world. The most thing I'd missed I think would be people, I'm used to speaking with my neighbours, greeting some friends and have small talk on the street with a drunk person.

2) The most modern city I'd been to is Moscow. I'm not really a fan of it's business, I have all this high tech because of all the business there is and I think it is two unseparable things: modern tech and level of business. I came to visit my friend there and for them it's a cool thing, but not for me, that's why I'm at Saint-Petersburg.

3) An old city for sure and without a doubt. I do like small streets, human-size buildings and a history of a place.

4) Population of Saint Petersburg is around 5.5 million people, and I think it will continue to grow in the upcoming years because there are a lot of places for working and studying.

The more people in the city the more creative and independent people it has, and then it has more different services, competitive market, etc.

